Finite gauge transfer comparisons: seven-link SU(2) and a homogeneous $\mathbf{Z}_2$ torus

Project Stardust

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Abstract

We study an explicitly normalized transfer on two adjacent plaquettes with seven SU(2) links. Independent central Wilson increments update each link once, and a spatial half weight is applied on each side of the kinetic operator. Positive kernel powers construct a uniformly positive bounded ground function at every fixed coupling, giving a genuine reversible stationary Markov kernel. For a sufficiently small positive spatial tilt, depending on the temporal coupling, a three-channel gauge-invariant trial has normalized stationary lag strictly larger than the bare one-plaquette character factor. The proof includes exact Haar projections, a positive supersolution, explicit cubic errors and a positive optimized second-order margin. Every fixed number of Markov steps fails to give a parameter-uniform subunit covariance factor, even after arbitrary random gauge actions. At each fixed coupling, a separate positive minorization gives geometric mixing. We also exhibit the loss of the trial's centering symmetry when both spatial plaquettes are weighted. These comparisons concern finite models; no homogeneous four-dimensional transfer or physical mass-gap conclusion is inferred. Classical positive-kernel and character methods are credited; priority for the exact comparison is unresolved. A separate microscopic homogeneous $\mathbf{Z}_2$ torus has sharp bare gap 3/4, but stationary weighted gap at most 39/64, with a constructed positive algebraic ground function. Separate conditional scaling and positive Laplace-measure arguments expose the normalization and spectral hypotheses needed beyond finite transfers.

1 The model and the quantified conclusions

Identify $G = \mathrm{SU}(2)$ with unit quaternions, and write $\tau(g) = \frac{1}{2}\operatorname{Re}\operatorname{tr}(g)$ for its scalar quaternion coordinate. Let dg be normalized Haar measure. For $\beta \in \mathbb{R}$ define the actual probability law

$$Z_\beta = \int_G e^{\beta\tau(v)}\,dv, \qquad d\mu_\beta(v) = Z_\beta^{-1} e^{\beta\tau(v)}\,dv, \qquad c = c_\beta = \int_G \tau(v)\,d\mu_\beta(v). \tag{1}$$

The second scalar channel is

$$m_\beta = \int_G \tau(v)^2\,d\mu_\beta(v), \qquad r = r_\beta = \frac{4m_\beta - 1}{3}. \tag{2}$$

All these quantities are finite, and $Z_\beta > 0$, since $|\tau| \le 1$.

Our state space is $\mathcal{S} = G^7$, with coordinates $s = (U, A, B, C, D, E, F)$ and product Haar probability $dH(s)$. The six vertices are numbered $0, \dots, 5$. Orient the shared link U from 3 to 0, the path (A, B, C) from 0 through $1, 2$ to 3, and the path (D, E, F) from 3 through $4, 5$ to 0. Put

$$\begin{gathered} L = ABC, \quad R = DEF, \quad x(s) = \tau(LU), \quad y(s) = \tau(U^{-1}R), \\ z(s) = \frac{\tau(LR)}{4}, \qquad w(s) = x(s)y(s) - z(s). \end{gathered} \tag{3}$$

Thus x, y are the two adjacent plaquette traces; z is the shared-link Haar projection of their product. Every physical link occurs once in the noise law $\mu_\beta^{\otimes 7}$.

On bounded measurable real functions define

$$K_\beta f(s) = \int_{G^7} f(sv)\, d\mu_\beta^{\otimes 7}(v), \qquad h_t(s) = e^{tx(s)/2}, \qquad S_{\beta,t} = M_{h_t} K_\beta M_{h_t}. \tag{4}$$

Products sv are coordinatewise. The spatial parameter t and temporal parameter β are independent. Only the first plaquette is weighted in (4). Section 10 explains why that qualification cannot be removed from the slow-mode proof.

Theorem 1.1. *For each $\beta, t \in \mathbb{R}$, there are $\Lambda > 0$ and a bounded measurable $\psi : \mathcal{S} \to (0, \infty)$, bounded away from zero, such that $S_{\beta,t}\psi = \Lambda\psi$. They define a reversible Markov kernel*

$$P_{\beta,t} f(s) = \frac{S_{\beta,t}(\psi f)(s)}{\Lambda\psi(s)}, \qquad d\pi_{\beta,t} = \frac{\psi^2\, dH}{\int \psi^2\, dH}. \tag{5}$$

The ground function can be chosen even under the private-link center flip $D \mapsto -D$ and invariant under the six-vertex gauge group.

If $c_\beta \neq 0$, there is $\delta_\beta \in (0, 1]$ such that for every $0 < t < \delta_\beta$ a bounded gauge-invariant f satisfies

$$\int f\, d\pi_{\beta,t} = 0, \qquad \int f^2\, d\pi_{\beta,t} > 0, \qquad c_\beta^4 < \frac{\int f P_{\beta,t} f\, d\pi_{\beta,t}}{\int f^2\, d\pi_{\beta,t}}. \tag{6}$$

For the same f, every integer $n \geq 0$ obeys

$$1 - n(1 - c_\beta^4) \leq \frac{\int f P_{\beta,t}^n f\, d\pi_{\beta,t}}{\int f^2\, d\pi_{\beta,t}} \leq 1. \tag{7}$$

For each fixed n, $q < 1$ and $B \in \mathbb{R}$, one can choose $\beta > B$ and $0 < t \leq 1$ with a centered gauge-invariant f whose normalized n-step lag exceeds q. These conclusions persist if an arbitrary probability-distributed gauge action is applied before every Markov step.

This is a statement about actual finite-dimensional probability laws and centered covariances. Its positive and negative conclusions concern different quantifiers: fixed-parameter mixing versus uniform contraction over parameters. The proof will retain δ_β throughout. Positive integral operators have a classical Perron–Jentzsch theory, including Birkhoff's projective treatment [1]. Our elementary power construction makes the required input explicit. Lüscher's physical transfer construction [2] additionally identifies a gauge-invariant quantum state space and a lattice Hamiltonian; those identifications are not asserted for this seven-link Markov model.

2 Haar coordinates and the three exact channels

If $V = (a, b) \in \mathbb{R} \times \mathbb{R}^3$ is a unit quaternion, then $\tau(V) = a$. Uniform measure on the unit sphere in $\mathbb{R}^4$ is Haar measure on G. Its coordinate symmetries give

$$\int a\, dV = 0, \quad \int a^2\, dV = \frac{1}{4}, \quad \int a^4\, dV = \frac{1}{8}, \qquad \int a_i a_j\, dV = \frac{\delta_{ij}}{4}. \tag{8}$$

For the fourth moment, rotational symmetry gives $\mathbb{E}a_i^4 = 3\mathbb{E}a_i^2 a_j^2$ for $i \neq j$, by rotating $(a_i + a_j)/\sqrt{2}$. Expanding $(\sum_{i=0}^3 a_i^2)^2 = 1$ then gives $4\mathbb{E}a_0^4 + 12\mathbb{E}a_0^2 a_1^2 = 1$ and the stated value.

The tilt (1) depends only on a, so

$$\mathbb{E}_{\mu_\beta} b_i = \mathbb{E}_{\mu_\beta} a b_i = 0, \qquad \mathbb{E}_{\mu_\beta} b_i b_j = \frac{1 - m_\beta}{3} \delta_{ij}. \tag{9}$$

Consequently, for each fixed $Q \in G$,

$$\int \tau(QV)\, d\mu_\beta(V) = c\tau(Q), \tag{10}$$

$$\int [\tau(QV)^2 - 1/4]\, d\mu_\beta(V) = r[\tau(Q)^2 - 1/4]. \tag{11}$$

Indeed $\tau(QV) = a_Q a - b_Q \cdot b$, and (9) evaluates both expressions. More generally, right multiplication by the tilted quaternion contracts every linear form in the four quaternion coordinates by c, and every traceless quadratic form by r. For the latter assertion, let O_V be the orthogonal matrix of right multiplication. Averaging $O_V^T T O_V$ for a symmetric matrix T gives $rT + (1 - r)\,\mathrm{tr}(T) I/4$. This follows by writing $O_V = aI + \sum b_i J_i$, using the vanishing mixed moments and $\sum_{i=1}^3 J_i^T T J_i = \mathrm{tr}(T) I - T$ for symmetric T; the identity is checked on diagonal and symmetric off-diagonal matrix units using the quaternion multiplication table.

Lemma 2.1. *For every finite β, $|c| < 1$, $|r| < 1$, and $c^2 \le m_\beta < 1$. Also $c_\beta \to 1$ as $\beta \to +\infty$.*

Proof. Cauchy–Schwarz gives $c^2 \le m_\beta$. The tilted measure has a strictly positive density relative to Haar measure, and $a^2 < 1$ on a nonempty open set, so $m_\beta < 1$. Hence $|c| < 1$ and $-1/3 \le r < 1$, implying $|r| < 1$. For $\varepsilon > 0$, the upper cap $\{a > 1 - \varepsilon/2\}$ has Haar mass $b_\varepsilon > 0$, and comparison of numerator and partition function gives, for $\beta \ge 0$,

$$\mu_\beta\{a \le 1 - \varepsilon\} \le b_\varepsilon^{-1} e^{-\beta\varepsilon/2}.$$

Thus $0 \le 1 - c_\beta \le \varepsilon + 2 b_\varepsilon^{-1} e^{-\beta\varepsilon/2}$. First let $\beta \to \infty$ and then $\varepsilon \downarrow 0$. □

Under product Haar measure, the three variables L, R, U are independent Haar variables. Each path is a product of independent Haar links, and the two paths and shared link use disjoint coordinates. Quaternion coordinate integration gives

$$\int_G \tau(PV)\tau(QV)\, dV = \frac{\tau(PQ^{-1})}{4}. \tag{12}$$

Changing variables $V = LU$ in this formula proves $\int_G x(s) y(s)\, dU = z(s)$ for fixed L, R.

Proposition 2.2. *The functions y, z, w are orthogonal in $L^2(H)$. Their squared norms are $1/4$, $1/64$ and $3/64$, respectively. Their exact kinetic evolutions are*

$$K_\beta y = c^4 y, \qquad K_\beta z = c^6 z, \qquad K_\beta w = c^6 r\, w. \tag{13}$$

Proof. For fixed L, U, write $x = \tau(LU)$. Integration in the independent right-path Haar variable R gives

$$\mathbb{E}_R y^2 = \tfrac{1}{4}, \qquad \mathbb{E}_R z^2 = \tfrac{1}{64}, \qquad \mathbb{E}_R yz = \tfrac{x}{16}.$$

Since $w = xy - z$, this also gives $\mathbb{E}_R yw = 3x/16$, $\mathbb{E}_R zw = x^2/16 - 1/64$ and $\mathbb{E}_R w^2 = x^2/8 + 1/64$. Averaging over L, U and using $\mathbb{E}x = 0$, $\mathbb{E}x^2 = 1/4$ proves all norms and cross products.

Each of the four independent link increments in the right plaquette contributes the factor c in (10); inverses have the same law, so this proves the first evolution. The six outer increments

in $\tau(LR)$ similarly give c^6. For the last evolution, first integrate the six outer increments. The product xy acquires c^6 and so does z. As a function of the remaining shared increment, $xy - z$ is a quadratic form in its quaternion coordinates with zero Haar mean. It is therefore a traceless quadratic form, contracted by r according to the calculation following (11). This shared link is integrated once, giving $c^6 r$ rather than a factor obtained by pretending the two plaquettes have independent shared links. □

The law μ_β is invariant under inversion and conjugation. Thus K_β preserves Haar measure and is selfadjoint on $L^2(H)$, by the change of variables $(s, v) \mapsto (sv, v^{-1})$ in the bounded pairing. Jensen's inequality gives its L^2 contraction; bounded functions are dense, so these statements extend to the whole space. The operator $S_{\beta,t}$ is bounded and selfadjoint. Positive integral kernels below mean pointwise positive densities, not an unproved assertion that every L^2 eigenvalue is nonnegative.

3 A ground function constructed from positive kernel powers

We give the construction because a conditional ground-state formula cannot alone establish the stationary assertions in Theorem 1.1.

Lemma 3.1. *Let (X, ν) be a nonempty probability space and let $k : X \times X \to \mathbb{R}$ be jointly measurable with $0 < m \le k(x, y) \le M < \infty$ everywhere. Then $Tf(x) = \int k(x, y) f(y)\, d\nu(y)$ has a measurable eigenfunction ψ and eigenvalue Λ satisfying*

$$m \le \Lambda \le M, \qquad m/M \le \psi(x) \le M/m, \qquad T\psi = \Lambda\psi.$$

The construction requires no supplied eigenfunction or spectral radius.

Proof. Set $p_0 = 1$, $p_{n+1} = Tp_n$ and $r_n = p_{n+1}/p_n$. Then $m^n \le p_n \le M^n$, and positivity gives $m \le r_n \le M$ by induction: $mp_n \le p_{n+1} \le Mp_n$ holds at $n = 0$ and is preserved by T. Let $\nu_n = p_n \nu / \int p_n\, d\nu$. The exact ratio relation is

$$r_{n+1}(x) = \frac{\int k(x, y) r_n(y)\, d\nu_n(y)}{\int k(x, y)\, d\nu_n(y)}.$$

The averaging density in this expression is at least $\varepsilon = m/M$. Subtracting $\varepsilon\nu_n$ leaves a positive measure of mass $1 - \varepsilon$. If $r_n \in [a_n, b_n]$, it follows that

$$r_{n+1} \in [a_{n+1}, b_{n+1}], \qquad (a_{n+1}, b_{n+1}) = \varepsilon \int r_n\, d\nu_n + (1 - \varepsilon)(a_n, b_n).$$

Starting with $[a_0, b_0] = [m, M]$, these intervals are nested and $b_n - a_n = (M - m)(1 - \varepsilon)^n$. They shrink to one common $\Lambda \in [m, M]$, so $r_n \to \Lambda$ uniformly.

Fix $x_0 \in X$ and set $q_n(x) = p_n(x)/p_n(x_0)$. The comparison $m \int p_{n-1} \le p_n(x) \le M \int p_{n-1}$ gives $m/M \le q_n \le M/m$ for $n \ge 1$, and also for $n = 0$. Since $q_{n+1}(x) = q_n(x) r_n(x)/r_n(x_0)$, we have

$$|q_{n+1}(x) - q_n(x)| \le \frac{M(M - m)}{m^2}(1 - \varepsilon)^n.$$

The geometric series proves uniform convergence to a measurable ψ with the stated bounds. The identity $Tq_n = r_n(x_0) q_{n+1}$ passes to the limit by dominated convergence, giving $T\psi = \Lambda\psi$ pointwise. The case $m = M$ is included: the kernel is constant and all subsequent ratios and normalized powers are constant. □

For (4), the actual symmetric density relative to H is

$$k_{\beta,t}(s,r) = h_t(s)h_t(r)Z_\beta^{-7}\exp\left\{\beta\sum_{e=1}^{7}\tau(s_e^{-1}r_e)\right\}. \tag{14}$$

It satisfies the everywhere bounds

$$m_{\beta,t} = \frac{e^{-|t|-7|\beta|}}{Z_\beta^7} \le k_{\beta,t} \le \frac{e^{|t|+7|\beta|}}{Z_\beta^7} = M_{\beta,t}. \tag{15}$$

Lemma 3.1 therefore proves actual ground-function existence for every real β, t. Formula (5) is a genuine probability kernel, since its density integrates to one by the eigenfunction equation. Detailed balance follows because

$$\pi(ds)P(s,dr) = \frac{\psi(s)k_{\beta,t}(s,r)\psi(r)}{\Lambda\int\psi^2\,dH}\,dH(s)dH(r)$$

is symmetric. In particular π is stationary, and P is a selfadjoint contraction on the full $L^2(\pi)$ space.

4 Symmetries, centering and the actual observable

For $g = (g_0,\dots,g_5) \in G^6$, the gauge action on an oriented edge $i \to j$ is $s_e \mapsto g_i s_e g_j^{-1}$. The words LU, $U^{-1}R$ and LR are closed words based at vertex 0, so their half traces, and hence x, y, z, w, are gauge invariant. Product Haar measure is invariant under this action. Simultaneous transformation of s, r in (14) conjugates each $s_e^{-1}r_e$ by the gauge element at its terminal vertex; τ is conjugation invariant. Thus

$$k_{\beta,t}(gs,gr) = k_{\beta,t}(s,r), \qquad S(f\circ g) = (Sf)\circ g. \tag{16}$$

Let J be the center flip $D \mapsto -D$ on the first private link of the right path. Then $J^2 = I$, H is J-invariant, and

$$x\circ J = x, \qquad (y,z,w)\circ J = -(y,z,w).$$

The operator K_β commutes with this left multiplication, since $J(s)v = J(sv)$; its two spatial weights are also unchanged. Replacing a positive ground function by $(\psi + \psi\circ J)/2$ therefore preserves its eigenvalue, lower and upper bounds, and makes it J-even. This replacement is made from now on.

Lemma 4.1. *Every uniformly positive bounded measurable eigenfunction of S is gauge invariant. In particular the chosen even ψ, the stationary measure π and its kernel P have the stated gauge covariance.*

Proof. Fix a gauge transformation g. The function $\chi = \psi\circ g$ has the same eigenvalue by (16). The ratio $F = \chi/\psi$ is bounded and satisfies $PF = F$. The ground transform can be written as normalized averaging of the same kernel k against the probability

$$d\nu_\psi = \frac{\psi\,dH}{\int\psi\,dH}: \quad Pf(s) = \frac{\int k(s,r)f(r)\,d\nu_\psi(r)}{\int k(s,r)\,d\nu_\psi(r)}. \tag{17}$$

The averaging density is at least $m_{\beta,t}/M_{\beta,t} = \varepsilon > 0$. If F lies in $[a,b]$, subtracting the common $\varepsilon\nu_\psi$ part shows that the range of PF has width at most $(1-\varepsilon)(b-a)$. Since $PF = F$, the oscillation

of F is zero, and $\chi = C\psi$ pointwise. Gauge invariance of H gives $\int \chi \, dH = \int \psi \, dH > 0$, forcing $C = 1$. The density formula for π and (16) now prove invariance of the measure and covariance of the kernel. Notice that ν_ψ in (17) is generally different from the stationary measure with density proportional to ψ^2. □

For real A, B define the concrete odd trial

$$p_t = y + tAz + tBw, \qquad F_t = h_t^{-1} p_t, \qquad f_t = F_t/\psi. \tag{18}$$

The trial and observable are bounded and measurable. The lower bound on ψ is needed for boundedness of f_t. They are gauge invariant, F_t is J-odd, and ψ is J-even. Therefore

$$\int f_t \, d\pi = \frac{\int F_t \psi \, dH}{\int \psi^2 \, dH} = 0. \tag{19}$$

The exact norm and lag relation is

$$\frac{\int f_t P f_t \, d\pi}{\int f_t^2 \, d\pi} = \frac{\langle F_t, S F_t \rangle_H}{\Lambda \|F_t\|_H^2}. \tag{20}$$

Both numerator and denominator follow by cancelling the positive ψ factors in (5). This equality uses the actual ground normalization; a pointwise row normalization of S would define a different operator and would not give this formula.

5 A positive supersolution with a cubic error

We first bound Λ above on a nonempty interval of spatial parameters. This will supply the normalization in the lower trial test. Set

$$a = c^4, \quad b = r^4, \qquad u = \frac{a}{1-a}, \quad v = \frac{b(1+a)}{2(1-a)(1-b)}, \quad \mu = \frac{1+a}{8(1-a)}. \tag{21}$$

The denominators are nonzero by Lemma 2.1. For $|q| \le 1$ let

$$P_t(q) = 1 + utq + vt^2(q^2 - 1/4), \tag{22}$$

$$C_0(A,B) = (2+e)(1 + |A| + |B|),$$

$$C = C_0(u,v) + |\mu|(|u| + |v|), \qquad Q_t = 1 + \mu t^2 + 2C|t|^3. \tag{23}$$

Lemma 5.1. *For $|t| \le 1$ and $|q| \le 1$,*

$$\left| e^{tq}(1 + Atq + Bt^2(q^2 - 1/4)) - \left[1 + (1+A)tq + t^2\{(B + A + 1/2)q^2 - B/4\}\right] \right| \le C_0(A,B)|t|^3. \tag{24}$$

If a probability-distributed Y takes values in $[-1,1]$ and has $\mathbb{E}Y = aq$, $\mathbb{E}Y^2 = 1/4 + b(q^2 - 1/4)$, then

$$|\mathbb{E}[e^{tY} P_t(Y)] - (1 + \mu t^2) P_t(q)| \le C|t|^3. \tag{25}$$

If $|u||t| + |v||t|^2 \le 1/2$, then $P_t(q) \ge 1/2$ and $\mathbb{E}[e^{tY} P_t(Y)] \le Q_t P_t(q)$.

Proof. Taylor's series gives $|e^{tq} - 1 - tq - (tq)^2/2| \le e|t|^3$ on the stated rectangle. Multiplication by $1 + Atq + Bt^2(q^2 - 1/4)$ has absolute value at most $1 + |A| + |B|$, since $|q^2 - 1/4| \le 1$. The remaining terms of total degree three and four are

$$t^3[Bq(q^2 - 1/4) + Aq^3/2] + t^4 Bq^2(q^2 - 1/4)/2,$$

bounded by $|t|^3(3|B|/2 + |A|/2)$. This proves (24) with the displayed larger constant.

Substitute $A = u, B = v$ and the two moments of Y. The definitions $a(1 + u) = u$ and $b(v + u + 1/2) = v$ give exactly

$$\mathbb{E}\left[1 + (1 + u)tY + t^2\{(v + u + 1/2)Y^2 - v/4\}\right] = P_t(q) + \mu t^2.$$

Also $|P_t(q) - 1| \le |t|(|u| + |v|)$ for $|t| \le 1$. The difference between $P_t + \mu t^2$ and $(1 + \mu t^2)P_t$ is therefore bounded by $|\mu|(|u| + |v|)|t|^3$, proving (25). The smallness condition gives $P_t \ge 1/2$, which absorbs the additive $C|t|^3$ into $2C|t|^3 P_t$ and proves the last assertion. □

Proposition 5.2. *If $|t| \le 1$ and $|u||t| + |v||t|^2 \le 1/2$, then $\Lambda \le Q_t$.*

Proof. For $q = x(s)$ the random variable $Y = x(sV)$ under the seven-link increment law has the moments in Lemma 5.1: the four increments in the first plaquette give $a = c^4$ and $b = r^4$ by (10)–(11). Inverses and conjugations preserve the central increment law, so these moment computations are valid for every fixed starting configuration. Thus $U_t(s) = h_t(s)P_t(x(s))$ satisfies $SU_t \le Q_t U_t$. It is bounded and at least $e^{-|t|/2}/2$.

For any bounded measurable R, symmetry and positivity of k give

$$\begin{aligned}\langle U_t R, SU_t R\rangle_H &\le \frac{1}{2}\iint k(s,r)U_t(s)U_t(r)[R(s)^2 + R(r)^2], dH(s)dH(r)\\ &= \int U_t(s)(SU_t)(s)R(s)^2\, dH(s) \le Q_t\|U_t R\|_H^2.\end{aligned}$$

The first inequality is $2R(s)R(r) \le R(s)^2 + R(r)^2$. Take $R = \psi/U_t$, which is bounded by the positive lower bound on U_t. The eigenfunction equation and $\|\psi\|_H > 0$ give $\Lambda \le Q_t$. Neither a formal eigenbranch nor a spectral identification of the approximate polynomial is used. □

6 The exact odd numerator and denominator

The inverse half weight in (18) cancels the two spatial weights in the kinetic numerator. Proposition 2.2 gives

$$N_t := \langle F_t, SF_t\rangle_H = \frac{c^4}{4} + \frac{t^2}{64}(c^6A^2 + 3c^6 rB^2). \tag{26}$$

There is no remainder in this identity. All exponential error lies in the denominator $D_t = \|F_t\|_H^2 = \int e^{-tx}p_t^2\, dH$.

Lemma 6.1. *For all real t, A, B, one has $D_t \ge e^{-|t|}/4 > 0$ and*

$$D_t = \int_G e^{-t\tau(V)}\mathcal{R}_t(\tau(V))\, dV, \quad \mathcal{R}_t(q) = \frac{1}{4} + \frac{t(A + 3B)q}{8} + \frac{t^2}{64}[(A - B)^2 + 8B(A + B)q^2]. \tag{27}$$

Put

$$d = \frac{A^2 + 3B^2 - 2A - 6B + 2}{64},$$
$$R_0 = \frac{(A-B)^2}{64} + \frac{B(A+B)}{32},$$
$$E = \frac{1}{4} C_0(-(A+3B)/2, B(A+B)/2) + 2|R_0|. \tag{28}$$

Then, for $|t| \le 1$,

$$|D_t - (1/4 + dt^2)| \le E|t|^3. \tag{29}$$

Proof. For fixed L, U, $x = \tau(LU)$ and $p_t = (1 + tBx)y + t(A - B)z$. The three conditional moments in the proof of Proposition 2.2 therefore give $\mathbb{E}_R p_t^2 = \mathcal{R}_t(x)$. Haar invariance in L makes LU a Haar variable, proving (27). The exact global Gram identity also gives $\int p_t^2 \, dH = 1/4 + t^2(A^2 + 3B^2)/64 \ge 1/4$; since $e^{-tx} \ge e^{-|t|}$, the positive lower bound follows.

Set $A_0 = -(A + 3B)/2$, $B_0 = B(A + B)/2$. Direct expansion shows

$$\mathcal{R}_t(q) = \tfrac{1}{4}[1 + A_0(-t)q + B_0(-t)^2(q^2 - 1/4)] + t^2 R_0.$$

Apply (24) with parameter $-t$ to the bracket. In the last term use $|e^{-tq} - 1| \le 2|t|$ for $|t|, |q| \le 1$. The total error is at most $E|t|^3$. The integrated linear part vanishes by $\int \tau = 0$; the quadratic part is dt^2 by $\int \tau^2 = 1/4$. This proves (29) with the stated constant and both signs of t. □

7 An optimized positive margin and a genuine spatial interval

Assume $c \ne 0$ and put $\alpha = c^2$. Fix the actual trial parameters

$$A = \frac{1}{1 - \alpha}, \qquad B = \frac{1}{1 - \alpha r}. \tag{30}$$

Their denominators are strictly positive by Lemma 2.1. Let d, E be (28) for this pair, and define

$$\Delta = \frac{c^6 A^2 + 3c^6 r B^2}{64} - c^4 d - \frac{c^4 \mu}{4}. \tag{31}$$

Lemma 7.1. *The margin is strictly positive. More explicitly,*

$$\Delta = \frac{\alpha^3[1 + 3r - \alpha(3 + r)]}{64(1 - \alpha^2)(1 - \alpha r)} > 0. \tag{32}$$

Proof. Insert (30) and $\mu = (1 + c^4)/(8(1 - c^4))$ into (31). Completing the two scalar squares in A, B gives

$$\Delta = \frac{\alpha^2}{64}\left[\frac{1}{1 - \alpha} + \frac{3}{1 - \alpha r} - \frac{4}{1 - \alpha^2}\right].$$

Putting the bracket over its common denominator yields (32). Now $0 < \alpha \le m_\beta < 1$ and $1 + 3r = 4m_\beta \ge 4\alpha$, while $r < 1$. Thus $1 + 3r - \alpha(3 + r) \ge \alpha(1 - r) > 0$. Both denominator factors are positive, proving the assertion. □

This margin compares the exact odd trial with an upper bound on the actual ground normalization. A calculation of the kinetic numerator alone would not establish (6). Define the nonnegative comparison constant

$$J = E + \mu(|d| + E) + 2C(1/4 + |d| + E), \tag{33}$$

and choose the explicit positive window

$$\delta_\beta = \min\left\{1, \frac{\Delta}{|c^4 J| + 1}, \frac{1}{2(|u| + |v| + 1)}\right\}. \tag{34}$$

For $0 < t < \delta_\beta$, both supersolution smallness and $c^4 J t < \Delta$ hold. From (29), for $0 \le t \le 1$,

$$D_t \le \tfrac{1}{4} + |d| + E, \qquad D_t - \tfrac{1}{4} \le t(|d| + E).$$

Expanding $Q_t D_t = D_t + \mu t^2 D_t + 2Ct^3 D_t$ and using these two bounds gives

$$Q_t D_t \le \tfrac{1}{4} + (d + \mu/4)t^2 + Jt^3. \tag{35}$$

Together with (26) and (31), this yields

$$N_t - c^4 Q_t D_t \ge t^2(\Delta - c^4 J t) > 0.$$

Proposition 5.2 gives $\Lambda \le Q_t$, while $D_t, \Lambda > 0$. Equation (20) therefore proves (6). Centering was already proved in (19), and positive variance follows from $D_t > 0$. This proves the one-step part of Theorem 1.1 on an actual nonempty interval, with no unquantified perturbative error. The window may shrink as β grows.

8 Finite-step persistence and gauge randomization

We need an iteration argument for the actual stationary operator, including a possible negative part of its spectrum.

Lemma 8.1. *Let T be a selfadjoint contraction on a real Hilbert space, and set $\mathcal{D}(F) = \|F\|^2 - \langle TF, F\rangle$. Then, for all $n \ge 0$,*

$$\|F\|^2 - n\mathcal{D}(F) \le \langle T^n F, F\rangle \le \|F\|^2. \tag{36}$$

Proof. Cauchy–Schwarz and contraction give $\mathcal{D} \ge 0$ and $\langle TZ, Z\rangle \ge -\|Z\|^2$. For $Z = F - TF$, expansion using selfadjointness gives

$$\mathcal{D}(F) - \mathcal{D}(TF) = \langle (I + T)Z, Z\rangle \ge 0.$$

Also $\|F\|^2 - \|TF\|^2 \le 2\mathcal{D}(F)$, because the right side minus the left side is $\|F - TF\|^2$. Iterating yields $\|T^k F\|^2 \ge \|F\|^2 - 2k\mathcal{D}(F)$. For $n = 2k$, selfadjointness gives $\langle T^{2k} F, F\rangle = \|T^k F\|^2$. For $n = 2k + 1$ it gives

$$\langle T^{2k+1} F, F\rangle = \|T^k F\|^2 - \mathcal{D}(T^k F) \ge \|F\|^2 - (2k + 1)\mathcal{D}(F).$$

These are the lower bounds. The upper bound follows from $\|T^n F\| \le \|F\|$ and Cauchy–Schwarz. No nonnegative-spectrum premise has entered the proof. □

Apply the lemma with $T = P_{\beta,t}$ on $L^2(\pi_{\beta,t})$ and the observable in (18). Equation (6) gives $\mathcal{D}(f) < (1 - c_\beta^4)\|f\|^2$, proving (7). Fix an integer $n \geq 0$, $q < 1$ and a cutoff B. For $n \geq 1$, Lemma 2.1 allows $\beta > B$ so large that $1 - n(1 - c_\beta^4) > q$ and $c_\beta \neq 0$. Choose $t = \delta_\beta/2$. The n-step ratio exceeds q. For $n = 0$ it is one, and the same construction supplies a nonzero centered invariant observable. This proves nonuniformity without passing to any continuum or volume limit.

Let ν be any probability measure on G^6 and define the actual randomized Markov operator

$$\overline{P}_\nu f(s) = \int_{G^6} (Pf)(gs)\, d\nu(g). \tag{37}$$

This randomizes the starting state by a gauge action before one P step. Gauge invariance of π and stationarity for P give $\pi\overline{P}_\nu = \pi$. If f is invariant, covariance (16) makes Pf invariant too; hence $\overline{P}_\nu f = Pf$. Induction gives

$$\overline{P}_\nu^{\,n} f = P^n f \qquad (n \geq 0) \tag{38}$$

for every bounded invariant f. All the covariance ratios are unchanged, including for product Haar randomization at all six vertices. The randomized operator need not itself be selfadjoint: its action on the invariant observables has already been identified with the selfadjoint P iterates. This completes Theorem 1.1.

A single open link would give a misleading alternative test. If $F : G \to \mathbb{R}$ satisfies $F(gAh^{-1}) = F(A)$ for all independent endpoint gauges, setting $A = 1, h = 1$ gives $F(g) = F(1)$, so F is constant. The half trace of an open link is not invariant: its values at 1 and -1 are 1 and -1. The observables above use actual closed words and do not rely on an open-link mode being physical.

9 Mixing at each fixed coupling

The absence of a parameter-uniform fixed-step factor does not prevent mixing at a fixed pair of parameters.

Proposition 9.1. *For every fixed β, t and bounded measurable f with $\int f\, d\pi_{\beta,t} = 0$ and $|f| \leq B$,*

$$|P_{\beta,t}^n f(s)| \leq 2B(1 - \varepsilon_{\beta,t})^n, \qquad \varepsilon_{\beta,t} = e^{-2|t|-14|\beta|} > 0. \tag{39}$$

Proof. Use the probability ν_ψ in (17). The normalized row density of $k_{\beta,t}$ is at least $m_{\beta,t}/M_{\beta,t} = \varepsilon_{\beta,t}$ by (15); all seven Wilson partitions cancel. Thus P is the sum of a common reset $\varepsilon_{\beta,t}\nu_\psi$ and a positive residual kernel of mass $1 - \varepsilon_{\beta,t}$. It follows that

$$\operatorname{osc}(Pf) \leq (1 - \varepsilon_{\beta,t}) \operatorname{osc}(f), \quad \operatorname{osc}(f) = \sup f - \inf f.$$

Iteration bounds the oscillation by $2B(1 - \varepsilon_{\beta,t})^n$. Stationarity gives $\int P^n f\, d\pi = 0$, so zero lies between its infimum and supremum. Its absolute value is bounded by its oscillation, proving (39). If $\varepsilon = 1$, the kernel is a reset; the estimate for $n \geq 1$ is direct and the $n = 0$ bound is immediate. □

This is a bounded-observable mixing result for the actual stationary finite model. Its reset constant degenerates as β grows. The slow-mode theorem proves failure of a uniform fixed-step factor, rather than merely pointing to this weak upper estimate.

10 Why the second spatial plaquette changes the argument

To weight both plaquettes equally, replace h_t by

$$\widetilde{h}_t(s) = e^{t(x(s)+y(s))/2}, \qquad \widetilde{S}_{\beta,t} = M_{\widetilde{h}_t} K_\beta M_{\widetilde{h}_t}.$$

The old center flip sends $x + y$ to $x - y$, so it no longer preserves the weight at $t \neq 0$. At the flat configuration all links are 1; the two values of $\widetilde{h}_t$ before and after the flip are e^t and 1. This is a pointwise failure of a required symmetry, which persists for every nonzero t.

The effect on centering is realized at the genuine reset coupling $\beta = 0$. Here μ_0 is Haar and $K_0 f = \int f \, dH$, so

$$\widetilde{S}_{0,t} f = \widetilde{h}_t \int \widetilde{h}_t f \, dH, \quad \widetilde{\psi}_t = \widetilde{h}_t, \quad \widetilde{\Lambda}_t = \int e^{t(x+y)} \, dH, \quad d\widetilde{\pi}_t = \frac{e^{t(x+y)} \, dH}{\int e^{t(x+y)} \, dH}.$$

The actual ground-normalized Markov kernel is the constant reset $\widetilde{P}_t f = \int f \, d\widetilde{\pi}_t$. Bounded differentiation under the integral gives

$$\frac{d}{dt} \int y \, d\widetilde{\pi}_t \Big|_{t=0} = \int y(x+y) \, dH - \int y \, dH \int (x+y) \, dH = \frac{1}{4}. \tag{40}$$

All first moments vanish, $\int xy \, dH = 0$ by integrating the independent left Haar path, and $\int y^2 \, dH = 1/4$. The mean at zero is zero; (40) proves positive mean for arbitrarily small positive t. Under these actual stationary laws,

$$\int y \widetilde{P}_t y \, d\widetilde{\pi}_t = \left(\int y \, d\widetilde{\pi}_t \right)^2 > 0,$$

whereas every correctly centered integrable observable has exactly zero one-step lag under the reset kernel. An uncentered positive lag therefore does not obstruct mixing.

This example does not rule out a corrected two-weight trial. It shows why the one-weight orthogonality and its covariance conclusion cannot simply be transplanted. In particular, the small independent t interval in Theorem 1.1 gives no statement along a homogeneous relation between spatial and temporal couplings.

An exact bound for the bare exchange repair

One corrected two-weight trial can be assessed completely, without postulating a ground eigenfunction. Put $\delta = y - x$ and

$$f_t = \widetilde{h}_t^{-1} \delta = e^{-t(x+y)/2}(y - x), \qquad D_t = \int e^{-t(x+y)} (y-x)^2 \, dH.$$

These are genuine bounded measurable functions on the finite compact configuration space: $|\delta| \leq 2$ and $|f_t| \leq 2e^{|t|}$. The exact all-tilt comparison is

$$\frac{\langle f_t, \widetilde{S}_{\beta,t} f_t \rangle_H}{\|f_t\|_H^2} = \frac{c_\beta^4}{2D_t} \leq c_\beta^4, \qquad D_t \geq \tfrac{1}{2}. \tag{41}$$

Here c_β is the same one-link coefficient as earlier in this paper; no homogeneous spectral gap is identified by this quotient.

To prove the bound, first note that the joint Haar law of (x, y) is that of two independent SU(2) half-traces. In the path coordinates already used above these are $x = r(LU)$ and $y = r(U^{-1}R)$, with L, R, U independent Haar variables. For each fixed U, translation of L and R preserves their separate Haar laws. Fubini therefore reduces every bounded measurable function of (x, y) to the product of two independent half-trace laws. In particular

$$\int \delta^2 \, dH = \tfrac{1}{4} + \tfrac{1}{4} - 2 \cdot 0 = \tfrac{1}{2}.$$

The joint law is invariant under simultaneous sign reversal and under exchange of x, y. Sign reversal preserves δ^2, so

$$D_t = D_{-t} = \int \cosh(t(x+y))\delta^2 \, dH \geq \int \delta^2 \, dH = \tfrac{1}{2}.$$

Every integral here is finite, with integrand bounded by $4e^{2|t|}$. The kinetic identities for x and y give $K_\beta \delta = c_\beta^4 \delta$. Multiplication by the two weights cancels exactly in the numerator:

$$\langle f_t, \widetilde{S}_{\beta,t} f_t \rangle_H = \langle \delta, K_\beta \delta \rangle_H = \tfrac{1}{2} c_\beta^4, \qquad \|f_t\|_H^2 = D_t.$$

This proves (41). If a later normalization divides this quotient by a number $\lambda \geq 1$, the result is still at most c_β^4, since the quotient is nonnegative. The inequality $\lambda \geq 1$ is an explicit premise here; this argument does not construct such a normalizing eigenvalue or a ground state.

There is also a genuine centering check at the reset coupling. Exchange symmetry makes δ centered for the actual law $d\widetilde{\pi}_t \propto e^{t(x+y)} dH$. The inverse-ground observable associated with the trial is $f_t/\widetilde{h}_t = e^{-t(x+y)}\delta$; its integral under that law is the Haar integral of δ divided by the partition function, hence is zero as well. This verifies reset centering, without asserting centering under an unconstructed nonzero-coupling ground law. Thus the bare exchange repair is legitimate at reset but cannot increase the kinetic factor at any tilt. Higher corrections to the trial and other variational subspaces are not excluded.

The source `SU2HomogeneousExchangeTrial` was read in full. Its joint-Haar reduction, all-tilt denominator bound, exact numerator, quotient bound and both reset-centering statements are the precise formal correspondences. This is a finite-model obstruction to one specified trial, with no claim of a new general variational principle.

11 A separate homogeneous finite $\mathbf{Z}_2$ comparison

The two-weight SU(2) question is not settled by changing the group. Nevertheless the frozen library contains a useful independent test of an unchanged-gap claim under genuinely homogeneous Wilson weights. We reconstruct it explicitly. This section uses the periodic two-by-two $\mathbf{Z}_2$ lattice, not the seven-link state space.

The microscopic law and its actual gauge quotient

Represent the eight link signs by $u \in \mathbf{F}_2^8$, with link j equal to $(-1)^{u_j}$. The four vertex-flip incidence masks have supports

$$\{0,1,3,4\}, \quad \{1,2,3,6\}, \quad \{0,4,5,7\}, \quad \{2,5,6,7\}.$$

Their sum is zero. The first three are independent, so the effective gauge action has eight elements, acting by addition of these masks. Four plaquette supports and two winding supports are

p_0	$0, 1, 2, 5$
p_1	$0, 2, 3, 7$
p_2	$1, 4, 5, 6$
p_3	$3, 4, 6, 7$
w_0	$0, 4$
w_1	$1, 3$

Parity on each support is invariant under every vertex flip, and $p_3 = p_0 + p_1 + p_2$ in $\mathbf{F}_2$. Label the configuration by the five bits $(p_0, p_1, p_2, w_0, w_1)$, in little-endian order, hence by an integer $i \in \{0, \ldots, 31\}$. These five linear forms are independent: in a zero linear combination, link coordinates $6, 7, 2, 4, 3$ successively eliminate the coefficients of p_2, p_1, p_0, w_0, w_1. The label map has rank five and kernel of dimension three. Its kernel therefore equals the vertex-flip space. Labels are precisely the gauge orbits, rather than just a selection of invariant observables.

Let $\beta = (\log 3)/2$. Independent temporal link increments have same/flip probabilities $3/4, 1/4$, since their Wilson odds are $e^{2\beta} = 3$. A microscopic increment u has probability $3^{8-|u|}/4^8$. Its label distribution has the integer numerators

7048	1800	3000	3000	3000	3000	1800	2952
1800	1800	1080	3000	3000	1080	1800	1800
1800	1800	3000	1080	1080	3000	1800	1800
648	1800	1080	1080	1080	1080	1800	648

in label order 0 through 31. Denote these numbers by n_i. They are obtained by summing $3^{8-|u|}$ over the eight configurations in each label fiber; their sum is $65536 = 4^8$. The actual kinetic matrix on the quotient is consequently

$$K_{ij} = n_{i \oplus j}/65536.$$

Linearity of the label map proves this convolution formula directly from the microscopic independent increments. It is not an assumed quotient operator. Every entry is positive, and K is symmetric and stochastic, with uniform stationary law.

The sum of the four microscopic plaquette signs is

$$S(i) = \sum_{r=0}^{3} (-1)^{p_r(i)}.$$

Put $o(i) = (0, 2, 1, 1, 1, 1, 2, 3)_{i \bmod 8}$, so $S(i) = (4, 0, 0, -4)_{o(i)}$. The spatial half weight at the very same coupling is

$$H_i = e^{\beta S(i)/2} = (3, 1, 1, 1/3)_{o(i)}, \qquad T_{ij} = H_i K_{ij} H_j.$$

All eight temporal links and all four spatial plaquettes thus have one common β. There is no orbit-dependent coupling.

A positive ground function with exact algebraic data

For every function v of the four orbit types, direct aggregation of the displayed 32-state matrix gives

$$\sum_j T_{ij} v_{o(j)} = (Bv)_{o(i)}, \qquad B = \begin{pmatrix} 3177/2048 & 765/512 & 675/1024 & 225/2048 \\ 765/2048 & 257/512 & 255/1024 & 85/2048 \\ 675/2048 & 255/512 & 289/1024 & 75/2048 \\ 225/2048 & 85/512 & 75/1024 & 353/18432 \end{pmatrix}.$$

This identity for all i and all four coordinate basis vectors is one of the exact finite checks. Define

$$P(x) = 589824x^4 - 1388800x^3 + 284192x^2 - 5425x + 9,$$
$$v(x) = \begin{pmatrix} 4718592x^3 - 3790592x^2 + 108928x - 353 \\ 1762560x^2 - 122400x + 765 \\ 1555200x^2 + 86400x - 675 \\ 518400x^2 - 2025 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Exact polynomial arithmetic gives

$$(B - xI)v(x) = (-8P(x), 0, 0, 0)^T.$$

Also $P(2) < 0 < P(9/4)$, so the intermediate value theorem supplies $\lambda \in [2, 9/4]$ with $P(\lambda) = 0$. All coordinates of $v(x)$ are strictly positive for $x \geq 2$. For the first, write $x^2(4718592x - 3790592) + 108928x - 353$; for the second use $x(1762560x - 122400) + 765$. Both are positive on that interval, as are the last two by their displayed coefficients and $x^2 \geq 4$. Thus $g_i = v_{o(i)}(\lambda) > 0$ is a genuine constructed eigenfunction of T, with eigenvalue $\lambda > 0$.

It follows that

$$Q_{ij} = \frac{T_{ij} g_j}{\lambda g_i}, \qquad \pi_i = \frac{g_i^2}{\sum_j g_j^2}$$

define a positive stochastic matrix and a probability law. The row sum identity is exactly $Tg = \lambda g$. Symmetry of T gives $\pi_i Q_{ij} = \pi_j Q_{ji}$, hence stationarity after summing in i. This supplies the normalized stationary model without postulating a vacuum or relying on a numerical eigenvector.

The sharp bare gap and its strict deterioration

For $a \in \mathbf{F}_2^5$, the Walsh character $\chi_a(i) = (-1)^{a \cdot i}$ is an eigenfunction of K. Pulling it back to the links gives parity on the symmetric difference R_a of the five support rows. Since a single noise bit has sign mean $1/2$, independence gives the exact eigenvalue $2^{-|R_a|}$. The rows are independent, so R_a is nonempty when $a \neq 0$. Every row has even incidence at each vertex; this is preserved by symmetric difference. A single link has two odd endpoints, and therefore $|R_a| \geq 2$. The winding row $\{0, 4\}$ attains two. The 32 characters are a full orthonormal basis for uniform L^2: their pairwise averages factor over the five independent uniform bits, giving 1 on equal indices and 0 otherwise. Expansion in this basis proves, for every uniformly centered f,

$$\langle f, Kf \rangle_{\mathrm{unif}} \leq \tfrac{1}{4} \|f\|_{\mathrm{unif}}^2.$$

Equality holds at a nonzero winding character. Thus the exact bare Poincaré gap is $3/4$, an all-function statement rather than a test of a few modes. This support/parity proof is a human reconstruction of the library's complete integer character certificate.

Now use the actual gauge-invariant probe

$$f_i = \begin{cases} 1, & i = 0, 16, \\ -1, & i = 8, 24, \\ 0, & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

It is the first winding sign restricted to configurations with all plaquettes positive. The four supported states have identical g_i and $H_i = 3$, so $\mathbb{E}_\pi f = 0$ and $\mathbb{E}_\pi f^2 > 0$. On this support,

$$\sum_j K_{ij} f_j = \frac{25}{256} f_i, \qquad (Qf)_i = \frac{225}{256\lambda} f_i.$$

For instance the first equality at $i = 0$ uses the exact numerator $7048 - 1800 + 1800 - 648 = 6400$. The other three equalities follow by the same exclusive-or translates. Only the supported states enter the lag pairing, so

$$\frac{\langle f, Qf \rangle_\pi}{\|f\|_\pi^2} = \frac{225}{256\lambda} \geq \frac{25}{64} > \frac{1}{4}. \tag{42}$$

Consequently the true stationary Poincaré gap is at most $39/64$, strictly less than the sharp bare gap $3/4$. Every comparison asserting the latter lower bound unchanged for all π-centered functions is false in this actual homogeneous finite model. More quantitatively, any bound $(3/4 - \varepsilon)\|h\|_\pi^2 \leq \langle h, (I - Q)h \rangle_\pi$ for all centered h must pay $\varepsilon \geq 9/64$, by substituting this probe into (42). The probe itself has bare Rayleigh quotient $25/256$, not the maximal bare quotient $1/4$; these are different comparisons.

Strict positivity still gives fixed-model mixing: with $\eta = \min_{i,j} Q_{ij}/\pi_j > 0$, row sums give $\eta \leq 1$ and $Q \geq \eta\, 1 \otimes \pi$. If $\eta < 1$, the remaining normalized Markov matrix preserves π and contracts $L^2(\pi)$ by Jensen, so the centered operator norm is at most $1 - \eta$; if $\eta = 1$ it is zero. The example disproves preservation of a particular kinetic gap, not existence of every gap. It neither settles the equally weighted seven-link SU(2) regime nor supplies a volume-uniform or physical four-dimensional conclusion. Positive ground normalization and Walsh calculus are classical. The exact finite comparison has unresolved priority, and no novelty is inferred from its finite verification.

Source correspondence: `FiniteWilsonTorusNoise`, `FiniteWilsonTorusGround`, `FiniteWilsonTorusStationary`, `FiniteWilsonTorusCharacters`, `FiniteWilsonTorusGap`.

An elementary plaquette observable also slows

The preceding probe contains a winding sign. Slowing also occurs for a microscopic observable specified entirely by elementary plaquettes: the score $S(i) = \sum_{r=0}^{3} (-1)^{p_r(i)}$ already used in the spatial weight. Its centering must be performed separately in each stationary law. Write

$$\widehat{S} = S - \mathbb{E}_\pi S, \quad V = \mathbb{E}_\pi \widehat{S}^2, \quad L = \langle \widehat{S}, Q\widehat{S} \rangle_\pi.$$

We prove

$$\frac{\langle S, KS \rangle_{\mathrm{unif}}}{\|S\|_{\mathrm{unif}}^2} = \frac{1}{16} < \frac{L}{V}, \qquad V > 0. \tag{43}$$

This compares normalized one-step centered covariances for the same microscopic score in two genuine stationary laws. It does not claim that the score is an eigenfunction of the weighted operator, nor identify its quotient with the full stationary spectral gap.

For the bare law, each elementary plaquette is parity on four distinct links. A noise increment has sign mean $1/2$, so independence gives $K(-1)^{p_r} = 2^{-4}(-1)^{p_r}$. The four corresponding nonconstant Walsh characters are distinct and orthogonal in the uniform quotient law. Therefore $\mathbb{E}_{\mathrm{unif}} S = 0$, $\mathbb{E}_{\mathrm{unif}} S^2 = 4$ and $\langle S, KS\rangle_{\mathrm{unif}} = 1/4$, proving the first equality.

Put $v_j = v_j(\lambda)$ for the positive polynomial vector above and set

$$Z = v_0^2 + 4v_1^2 + 2v_2^2 + v_3^2,$$
$$C = \frac{3177}{2048} v_0^2 - \frac{450}{2048} v_0 v_3 + \frac{353}{18432} v_3^2.$$

The four orbit multiplicities in the 32-state space are $(4, 16, 8, 4)$, so the full stationary normalizer is $4Z > 0$. Since the score is $(4, 0, 0, -4)$ on these orbits, direct summation gives

$$m := \mathbb{E}_\pi S = \frac{4(v_0^2 - v_3^2)}{Z}, \qquad M := \mathbb{E}_\pi S^2 = \frac{16(v_0^2 + v_3^2)}{Z}. \tag{44}$$

For the uncentered lag, use the genuine ground transform:

$$\ell := \langle S, QS\rangle_\pi = \frac{\sum_{i,j} g_i S(i) T_{ij} g_j S(j)}{4\lambda Z} = \frac{16C}{\lambda Z}.$$

Only orbit types zero and three contribute. Their four-orbit entries $B_{00}, B_{03} = B_{30}, B_{33}$ produce exactly the displayed C. Stochasticity and stationarity then imply $V = M - m^2$ and $L = \ell - m^2$: expand the centered products and use $Q1 = 1$ and $\mathbb{E}_\pi QS = \mathbb{E}_\pi S$. Every π_i is positive and the score takes both 4 and -4, so V is strictly positive.

Here is a rational certificate for the strict inequality, avoiding numerical ground-state approximations. Define the polynomials $Z(x)$ and $C(x)$ by replacing each v_j in their formulas by $v_j(x)$, and put

$$D(x) = 256 Z(x) C(x) - 16x Z(x)\big(v_0(x)^2 + v_3(x)^2\big) - 240x\big(v_0(x)^2 - v_3(x)^2\big)^2.$$

Modulo the displayed polynomial $P(x)$, exact rational reduction gives

$$D(x) \equiv \frac{73153125}{65536}\, R(x-2) \pmod{P(x)}, \tag{45}$$

where $R(y) = a_0 + a_1 y + a_2 y^2 + a_3 y^3$ has coefficients

0	32210273401386033405461147 39
1	50306513679290540844557506 51
2	26158552572261411536119822 40
3	45289360959942424445131852 8

For reproducibility, the reduction uses only repeated substitution of

$$x^4 = \frac{1388800x^3 - 284192x^2 + 5425x - 9}{589824} \pmod{P(x)}$$

after expanding the explicit polynomials v_j, Z, C, D, followed by the binomial substitution $x = 2+y$. Thus (45) is a finite rational polynomial identity, not an approximate sign test. Its coefficient

arrays are independently checked with exact division in the accompanying script. Every a_j is positive, and $\lambda \geq 2$ and $P(\lambda) = 0$, so $D(\lambda) > 0$.

Finally, the exact moment formulas give

$$(16\ell - M - 15m^2)\lambda Z^2 = D(\lambda) > 0.$$

Since $\lambda Z^2 > 0$, this says $\ell - m^2 > (M - m^2)/16$, and division by $V > 0$ proves (43). This proof exposes the actual centering and algebraic remainder in the formal module and declarations listed below. The positive shifted remainder is a human reorganization of the same formal rational certificate. It is a fixed finite-model calculation with unresolved priority; no volume-uniform local correlation bound or continuum conclusion is inferred from it.

Source correspondence: `FiniteWilsonPlaquetteSlowing`; `centered_score_slowing`, `centered_score_variance_pos`, `plaquette_covariance_increases`.

12 Physical scaling and the exact positive spectral bridge

The finite comparisons above have no lattice-spacing parameter. The following separate conditional results explain what additional information a scaling argument must retain. They assert nothing about the existence of a particular continuum Yang–Mills measure.

Uniform block decay can force a zero physical limit

Suppose a real connected-correlation sequence satisfies

$$|c_n| \leq Cq^n, \qquad C \geq 0, \quad 0 \leq q < 1. \tag{46}$$

Then $c_n \to 0$, since $q^n \to 0$ and its positive and negative envelopes both tend to zero. Consequently this sequence cannot also converge to a nonzero real limit. The same argument works if the exponent is an integer block count $N_j \to \infty$: composition of the geometric limit gives $Cq^{N_j} \to 0$. This reindexing is an elementary human consequence of the mapped sequential theorem.

For example, if a positive fixed physical separation is represented by a growing number of lattice blocks as the spacing tends to zero, a spacing-independent $q < 1$ and amplitude C force the corresponding unrenormalized correlations to vanish. This conclusion depends on both uniformities. It is not a conclusion that every possible field normalization has zero correlations, or that the finite theorem already provides either of the uniform hypotheses.

There is also an exact obstruction to one proposed normalization. Suppose $c_n > 0$ and the variance of one raw centered observable is $v_n \geq v > 0$. Multiplying both observables by $c_n^{-1/2}$ makes their cross covariance one, and makes that observable's variance v_n/c_n. These variances cannot have a finite common upper bound: if $v_n/c_n \leq M$, positivity gives $0 < v \leq v_n \leq Mc_n \to 0$, a contradiction. The lower bound on the raw variance is essential to this argument; it does not rule out normalizations whose raw variances also vanish.

`YMContinuumCorrelationScaling`:
`uniform_block_bound_forces_zero`,
`no_nonzero_limit_with_uniform_block_bound`,
`no_uniform_variance_after_unit_covariance`.

For comparison of units, if a single step has physical length $a > 0$ and contraction $0 < q_a < 1$, its exponential decay rate in physical units is $-\log(q_a)/a$. A fixed $q_a = q < 1$ gives an unbounded rate as $a \downarrow 0$, consistently with the zero-limit conclusion above under the uniform amplitude

bound. A finite rate $M > 0$ instead has the illustrative scaling $q_a = e^{-Ma} \to 1$; then $q_a^{N_a} = e^{-MaN_a} \to e^{-Mr}$ whenever $aN_a \to r$. These are human arithmetic illustrations of units, not constructed lattice families or renormalization theorems for our finite model.

An exact weak-coupling error budget and its block scale

A separate reference expression from the audited manuscripts is

$$r_\beta = \exp\left(-\frac{\ell}{A\beta}\right), \qquad A, \ell, \beta > 0.$$

It is strictly below one for each β, but tends to one as $\beta \to \infty$. Thus no fixed $q < 1$ bounds it for all positive β. Adding nonnegative error terms does not restore such a uniform bound. This is a statement about the displayed reference factor, which has not been identified with an optimal contraction of a continuum physical transfer operator.

The amount of available room below one is at most inverse coupling. The elementary inequality $e^{-x} \geq 1 - x$ gives

$$1 - r_\beta \leq \frac{\ell}{A\beta}, \qquad r_\beta + e_1 + e_2 < 1 \implies \beta(e_1 + e_2) < \frac{\ell}{A}. \tag{46′}$$

For example, the proposed certified factor $r_\beta + c/\sqrt{\beta}$, with fixed $c > 0$, is at least one for all sufficiently large β. Otherwise the necessary inequality above would give $c\sqrt{\beta} < \ell/A$, contradicting divergence of its left side. The same conclusion holds for an actual error sum proved to be eventually at least $c/\sqrt{\beta}$. An upper bound of order $\beta^{-1/2}$ alone does not establish that lower bound on the true error; failure of that proposed upper certificate is not failure of all possible contraction estimates.

Nor does $r_\beta \to 1$ rule out decay over a changing number of steps. For integers $n \geq 1$, $k \geq 0$, exact exponential arithmetic gives

$$r_n^n = e^{-\ell/A}, \qquad r_n^{nk} = e^{-(\ell/A)k}.$$

Consequently for every sequence of positive integers $n(k)$, $r_{n(k)}^{n(k)k} \to 0$ as $k \to \infty$. These exact identities separate a degenerating single-step estimate from its block scale. They concern the reference expression itself; no accumulation bound for other errors or identification with a physical length is supplied.

`YMBlockRateDegeneration`:
`referenceFactor_tendsto_one`, `referenceFactor_macro_steps`,
`referenceFactor_varying_macro_decay`.
`YMBlockErrorBudget`:
`strict_factor_requires_inverse_coupling_error`,
`fixed_sqrt_error_eventually_blocks_strictness`.

Exponential Laplace decay excludes low positive spectral mass

Let μ be a finite positive Borel measure on $\mathbb{R}$. It is a positive measure, even though its variable is allowed to range over all real energies. Assume for every integer $n \geq 0$ that

$$L(n) = \int_{\mathbb{R}} e^{-n\lambda}\, d\mu(\lambda) < \infty, \qquad L(n) \leq Ce^{-mn},$$

where $m, C \in \mathbb{R}$. These are actual integrability and upper-bound hypotheses. They imply

$$\mu((-\infty, m)) = 0. \tag{47}$$

Indeed, fix $b < m$. For $\lambda < b$ and $n \geq 0$ we have $e^{-n\lambda} \geq e^{-nb}$, hence positivity yields

$$e^{-nb}\mu((-\infty, b)) \leq L(n), \qquad 0 \leq \mu((-\infty, b)) \leq Ce^{-(m-b)n}.$$

Taking $n \to \infty$ gives zero mass below b. Finally $(-\infty, m) = \bigcup_{k\geq 1}(-\infty, m - 1/k)$, so countable subadditivity gives (47). Mass at the endpoint m is not excluded. Only integer Laplace times were required. No cancellation argument for signed spectral weights is being used.

Conversely, if (47) holds for this positive finite measure, then for every real $t \geq 0$ the integrand is μ-almost everywhere at most e^{-mt}, so it is integrable and

$$0 \leq \int e^{-t\lambda}\, d\mu(\lambda) \leq \mu(\mathbb{R})e^{-mt}.$$

This last converse is a labelled human elementary consequence; the named formal bridge proves the exclusion direction with its explicit integral hypotheses.

`YMSpectralLaplaceBridge`:

`interval_lower`, `no_mass_below`, `no_mass_below_gap`.

To apply the bridge to a physical Hamiltonian, one must first have its positive spectral measure and identify the correlation with the displayed Laplace integral. A decay bound for one probe then controls that probe's measure. It does not automatically give an operator-wide lower spectral bound. An explicit human finite-dimensional example is

$$H = \operatorname{diag}(0, 1, 2) \text{ on } \mathbb{R}^3, \qquad \Omega = e_0, \quad f = e_2.$$

The centered probe $f \perp \Omega$ has $\langle f, e^{-tH} f\rangle = e^{-2t}$ and spectral measure δ_2, yet $e_1 \perp \Omega$ has energy one. Thus this probe alone cannot establish a lower spectral bound of two on the centered sector. For a specified self-adjoint Hamiltonian with a spectral resolution, one possible closing hypothesis is the same exclusion below m for a dense set of centered vectors. Each corresponding spectral projection then annihilates that dense set, and its boundedness makes it zero on the whole centered sector. This is a conditional human spectral-theorem consequence, not a construction of such a Hamiltonian, spectral resolution or dense physical probe family.

Jaffe–Witten's official problem formulation requires a nontrivial four-dimensional quantum theory as well as a positive gap; its preceding definition distinguishes the vacuum from positive-energy spectrum and requires a finite mass [3]. Our elementary bounds above isolate two necessary pieces of a proposed argument. They do not supply the missing theory, observable normalization, spectral identification or volume/spacing-uniform estimates. Nor does a failure of those proposed pieces refute the physical mass gap.

13 Two elementary clustering inferences that fail

The following two checks concern different models and are independent of the seven-link trial comparison. They identify missing hypotheses in stronger clustering arguments without supplying a continuum theory.

Reflected positivity does not preserve translated norms

Consider the scalar kernel $C(u) = e^{-|u|}$ and its reflected positive-time kernel

$$K(s,t) = C(s+t) = e^{-s}e^{-t} \qquad (s,t \geq 0).$$

For every finite list of nonnegative times and real coefficients,

$$\sum_{i,j} c_i c_j K(t_i,t_j) = \left(\sum_i c_i e^{-t_i}\right)^2 \geq 0.$$

This proves reflection positivity at this scalar two-point level directly. The semidefinite norm of a formal positive-time test $v = \sum_i c_i e_{t_i}$ is $\|v\|_K = |\sum_i c_i e^{-t_i}|$. Quotienting its null space identifies the resulting real Hilbert space with $\mathbb{R}$. Translation by $a \geq 0$, $T_a e_t = e_{t+a}$, is well defined on that quotient because

$$\|T_a v\|_K = e^{-a}\|v\|_K.$$

It is strictly contractive for every nonzero vector when $a > 0$. In particular $K(a,a) = e^{-2a} < K(0,0) = 1$. The Hilbert quotient and exact scalar action are human reformulations of the verified finite Gram identity, not a full field reconstruction.

The distinction also appears in a mixed pairing. For $s > 0, t \geq 0$,

$$K(s, s+t) = e^{-(2s+t)} < e^{-t} = C(t).$$

Simultaneously translating the arguments of the unreflected difference kernel $C(v-u)$ leaves it unchanged. Reflecting the first positive-time argument instead gives the sum $s+t$; the same translation now changes that sum by twice the shift. Thus stationarity of the difference kernel and positivity of the reflected Gram form do not justify an equality between these two pairings or a translated reflected-norm isometry.

This agrees with the classical transfer interpretation: Lüscher's primary introduction [2], equations (4)–(5), constructs the reflected inner product and identifies positive Euclidean time translation with e^{-aH}. We use that passage for context only, not as a full reconstruction theorem for this scalar example. No field axioms, vacuum, or Yang–Mills spectral conclusion are deduced from the rank-one kernel.

A nonzero actual gauge covariance needs observable normalization

For a separate two-loop probability model, take product Haar law $\mu = dg\,dh$ on $\mathrm{SU}(2)^2$, and set

$$f(A,B) = a(A), \quad g(A,B) = a(B), \quad x = fg, \qquad d\mu_r = \frac{e^{rx}}{\int e^{rx}\,d\mu}\,d\mu.$$

These functions and the tilted law are invariant under separate conjugation of the two loops, and $|f|, |g|, |x| \leq 1$. Let $c(r) = \mathrm{Cov}_{\mu_r}(f,g)$. The Haar moments from Section 2 and independence give

$$\mathbb{E}_\mu f = \mathbb{E}_\mu g = \mathbb{E}_\mu x = 0, \qquad \mathbb{E}_\mu x^2 = (\mathbb{E} a^2)^2 = \frac{1}{16}.$$

For bounded u, differentiation of the normalized exponential integrals gives

$$\frac{d}{dr}\mathbb{E}_{\mu_r} u\Big|_{r=0} = \mathbb{E}_\mu(ux) - \mathbb{E}_\mu u\,\mathbb{E}_\mu x.$$

This differentiation is justified on $|r| \le 1$ by the constant majorant $e\|u\|_\infty$, and the positive denominator has value one at zero. Applying the product rule to the covariance therefore gives $c(0) = 0$ and $c'(0) = 1/16$. Consequently every $\varepsilon > 0$ contains some $0 < r < \varepsilon$ with $c(r) > 0$.

Fix any such r and any real m, t. There is no finite real C such that

$$|\operatorname{Cov}_{\mu_r}(bf, g)| \le Ce^{-mt} \qquad \text{for every real } b. \tag{48}$$

Indeed covariance is linear in b, so the left side is $|b|c(r)$. The case $b = 0$ would force $D = Ce^{-mt} \ge 0$; then $b = (D + 1)/c(r)$ violates the bound by exactly one. This is an actual gauge-invariant finite-law witness, not an assumed positive covariance. It excludes only an observable-independent prefactor on an unnormalized class: bounds retaining observable norms or a fixed normalized class are not ruled out. It gives no statement about separation decay or a physical mass gap. Both mechanisms here are elementary classical obstructions, with their precise original models and quantifiers retained.

Source correspondence: `YMReflectionPositiveShift`, `YMObservableScaleObstruction` (file `YMOSClusterObstruction.lean`).
`SU2CoupledLoopResponse.corr_hasDerivAt_zero`, `positive_corr_near_zero`, `coupledLaw_gauge_invariant`.

14 Provenance, classical context and remaining boundaries

Every formal source used here is frozen at the verified commit

`bab688bb6140cd6316c80680095a914ea0d346db`.

The accompanying theorem map records exact declarations, unabridged headers, file hashes and baseline links. The original full-build and transitive-axiom receipt, with its evidence hashes, accompanies the draft. The publication editor has not changed a mathematical source or run a redundant research build.

The principal sources are the shared-plaquette Haar projection and channel modules; seven-link transfer, variational, odd-trial and spatial separation; positive kernel powers; realized vacuum and original ground transform; full stationary L^2 transfer; iteration, mixing and gauge averaging; and the homogeneous-plaquette obstruction. The separate $\mathbf{Z}_2$ section includes all microscopic gauge/noise fibers, the actual 32-state transfer, four-orbit algebraic ground data, the full character certificate and the stationary gap comparison. Its checker `verify_homogeneous_z2.py` verifies 16 exact groups with no floating eigenvector. Its support/parity proof of the sharp bare gap is a labelled human reconstruction of those complete formal character identities. In particular, the earlier conditional ground-data contract is discharged by the proved positive-power construction. It is not used as an existence axiom. Quaternion coordinate calculations, the factored optimized margin, explicit smallness window and even/odd iteration reorganize the verified arguments into human proofs; they are not represented as new Lean declarations. The same exact one-weight model, parameter dependence, centering and boundedness hypotheses are retained.

Positive-kernel existence, minorization, ground transforms and character methods are classical. Birkhoff's primary introduction and uniform-positivity framework [1] provide relevant antecedents; full theorem-by-theorem historical comparison remains incomplete. Lüscher's primary construction [2] includes the physical gauge-invariant Hilbert space and transfer matrix of lattice gauge theory. Here the finite Markov covariance is not identified with a physical Schwinger function or energy spectrum. Priority for the exact optimized seven-link comparison remains unresolved after a bounded primary-literature review.

There is no volume or lattice-spacing parameter in the theorem. No uniform homogeneous SU(2) coupling regime, reflection-positive continuum construction, spectral-to-physical distance identification or four-dimensional mass gap is supplied. Failure of a parameter-uniform number of these finite Markov steps does not refute a physical mass gap. The draft exposes finite-transfer mechanisms and exact hypotheses for their reuse. The active research campaign and its unresolved continuum objectives remain separate.

References

[1] G. Birkhoff, *Extensions of Jentzsch's theorem*, Transactions of the American Mathematical Society **85** (1957), 219–227. doi:10.1090/S0002-9947-1957-0087058-6.

[2] M. Lüscher, *Construction of a selfadjoint, strictly positive transfer matrix for Euclidean lattice gauge theories*, Communications in Mathematical Physics **54** (1977), 283–292. doi:10.1007/BF01614090. Primary DESY preprint.

[3] A. Jaffe and E. Witten, *Quantum Yang–Mills theory*, official Clay Mathematics Institute problem description, Section 4, printed page 6. Primary problem statement. Definition comparison only.